American efforts to improve relations with India were part of a strategy to "wean them away from the Soviet Union." Given that Beijing had been pressing Washington to do more on both the economic and military fronts for Pakistan, US officials also emphasized that improved US-India relations would have the added benefit of giving the administration domestic flexibility to do more for Pakistan. Ford and Kissinger added that it would also allow the US to restrain India vis-à-vis Pakistan and Bangladesh, and generally influence India on a variety of subjects of interest to China.[44]

Intelligence analysts expected Sino-US relations to be a potential problem in US-India relations.[45] In discussions with Indian officials, however, American officials made no secret of the fact that they were continuing to try to improve relations with Beijing. They did try to assure Indian officials that Sino-US rapprochement was not "directed against India." Kissinger also told senior Indian policymakers that the US had "absolutely no interest to let China weaken India. Our relations with China were a marriage of convenience." He noted that the US also had no interest in China acting in a way that would increase instability in the subcontinent. He further assured Indian policymakers that the US "discouraged any Chinese adventures," and any Chinese attack on India would be looked upon "with extreme disfavor."[46] What he did not say to them, but admitted internally, was that as things stood during the Ford administration, "It is almost certainly true that if the Chinese attacked we would support India, but we don't want the Chinese to think we are dumping them for the Indians."[47]

Sino-Indian Relations and the US (1973–1976)

Indian officials realized that the US would take no steps on US-India relations that would "displease" China, but they did not expect that China would be a subject of conflict between the US and India as it had been in 1971. They reiterated to their American counterparts that they welcomed Sino-US rapprochement, but hoped it would not be at India's expense and that Washington might indeed be able to influence positively Chinese views of the subcontinent.[48]

There was another reason that Indian officials no longer saw the Sino-US relationship as highly problematic: the US could potentially facilitate